First Aid for Common Sports Injuries

First aid is the immediate help given before professional care arrives. It does not replace a doctor. When in doubt, get medical help.

Check the Scene First

Make sure the area is safe and stop the game. If the person is unresponsive, not breathing normally, or bleeding heavily, call for help right away. The Philippine emergency hotline is 911.

Sprains vs Strains

- Sprain: a stretch or tear of a ligament. Ligaments connect bone to bone at a joint. Rolling your ankle is a classic example.
- Strain: a stretch or tear of a muscle or tendon. Tendons connect muscle to bone. A pulled hamstring is an example.

Memory trick: strain has a "t", like tendon.

The RICE Method

RICE is the usual first response for mild sprains and strains.

- Rest: stop playing and keep weight and stress off the injured part.
- Ice: apply a cold pack wrapped in a thin cloth for about 15 to 20 minutes at a time, every two to three hours. Never put ice on bare skin.
- Compression: wrap the area with an elastic bandage, snug but not tight. If fingers or toes turn pale, cold, numb, or tingly, loosen it.
- Elevation: raise the injured part above heart level when possible.

If the person cannot bear weight, or pain and swelling are severe, suspect a fracture and get it checked.

Fractures

A fracture is a broken or cracked bone. Signs include severe pain, swelling, an odd-looking limb, and being unable to move the part. In an open fracture, bone breaks through the skin.

- Do not straighten the limb or push bone back in.
- Immobilize it in the position found, with a splint supporting the joints above and below the break. A rolled magazine or padded board can work.
- Cover an open wound with a clean dressing without pressing on the bone.
- Get medical care for every suspected fracture.

Dislocations

A dislocation happens when bone ends are forced out of place at a joint. Shoulders and fingers are common sites. Never try to pop it back in, because you may damage nerves or blood vessels. Support the joint in a comfortable position, apply a wrapped cold pack, and bring the person to a doctor.

Muscle Cramps

A cramp is a sudden, painful, involuntary tightening of a muscle, often the calf or thigh. Fatigue and dehydration in our hot weather can trigger it. Stop, then gently stretch and massage the muscle, and sip water or a sports drink. Most cramps pass in minutes.

Nosebleeds

- Sit up and lean slightly forward. Do not tilt the head back, because blood can run down the throat.
- Pinch the soft part of the nose, below the bony bridge, for 10 to 15 minutes without letting go.
- Get medical help if bleeding lasts beyond about 20 minutes or the nose may be broken.

Heat Exhaustion vs Heat Stroke

- Heat exhaustion: heavy sweating, cool clammy skin, weakness, dizziness, headache, nausea, and a fast, weak pulse. Move the person to shade, loosen clothing, cool them with wet towels or a fan, and give sips of water if they are alert. If there is no improvement within about an hour, or they get worse, seek medical help.
- Heat stroke: a life-threatening emergency where the body can no longer cool itself. Signs include very high body temperature, confusion, slurred speech, fainting, or seizures. Call 911 and cool the person fast, ideally by immersing the body in cold water, or by soaking them and placing ice packs on the neck, armpits, and groin. Give no drinks if they are confused.

Concussion

A concussion is a brain injury from a blow to the head or a hard jolt to the body. Losing consciousness is not required. Signs include headache, dizziness, confusion, blurred vision, vomiting, memory gaps, and poor balance.

If you suspect one, remove the player right away and do not let them return that day: "when in doubt, sit them out." A doctor should clear them before they play again. Call 911 for loss of consciousness, a worsening headache, repeated vomiting, a seizure, or unequal pupils.

Sports First Aid Kit

- Disposable gloves
- Instant cold packs
- Elastic and triangular bandages
- Sterile gauze pads and adhesive bandages
- Adhesive tape and scissors
- Antiseptic wipes
- A splint or padded board
- Emergency numbers and each player's emergency contact

When to Call Emergency Help

Call 911 for unconsciousness, trouble breathing, chest pain, heat stroke signs, a possible head, neck, or back injury, an open or obvious fracture, or heavy bleeding. Do not move someone with a possible neck or back injury unless they are in danger.

Quick check

- Q: What tissue is injured in a sprain? A: A ligament, which connects bone to bone.

- Q: What does RICE stand for? A: Rest, ice, compression, elevation.
- Q: Should you tilt the head back during a nosebleed? A: No. Lean forward and pinch the soft part of the nose.
- Q: Which heat illness causes confusion and is an emergency? A: Heat stroke.
- Q: Can a player with a suspected concussion return to the same game? A: No. Remove them from play and have a doctor check them first.